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# Women's financial planning for retirement

## Systematic literature review and future research agenda

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### Abstract

**Purpose** – The purpose of this paper is to examine the status of the research on women's financial planning for retirement. This paper provides a brief review of the work carried out so far along with a conceptual framework of factors influencing women's retirement financial planning. In addition, it lists significant gaps and recommends avenues for future research.
**Design/methodology/approach** – The review is based on 151 articles appearing in various peer-reviewed journals published during 1980–2017. The study establishes its prominence by studying the publication activities based on the year of publication and region, citation analysis, research designs, data analysis techniques and findings from the selected articles.
**Findings** – Most of the literature on women's financial planning for retirement indicates a lack of financial management amongst women and their susceptibility to poverty in postretirement years. The majority of the research works in this field have taken place in developed economies. Empirical research with regression-based models for analysis is the most popular research design. This review also highlights the significant determinants of women's retirement financial planning as identified through literature. These include socio-demographic factors, psychological constructs, financial literacy, economic and circumstantial forces.
**Originality/value** – This paper covers the research works done in this area in the past 38 years. To the best of authors' knowledge, this is the first attempt to provide a systematic and comprehensive compilation of the knowledge in this subject. It further synthesizes the findings of various studies on factors influencing women's retirement financial planning and gives recommendations for future studies.

**Keywords** Women, Citation analysis, Financial planning

**Paper type** Literature review

### 1. Introduction

The financial planning entails a comprehensive assessment of one's current and future financial status. It is an ever-evolving process of meeting one's life goals (be it buying a house, children's higher education, setting up of an enterprise, etc.) through the adequate management of finances. Financial planning is in itself a complex multidimensional task and includes a wide array of activities, such as cash flow management, savings, investments, tax planning, real estate management, insurance planning and retirement planning.

For a very long time, financial planning by individuals was present in a crude form. However, with the steady rise in the standard of living, introduction of complex financial instruments and taxation, sophisticated forms of financial planning came into picture. Although financial planning became more intricate, it failed to achieve its due importance at academic, organizational and consumer levels (Altfest, 2004). Moreover, finances are considered as the forte of male members of the society. Mostly, men undertake the task of financial management and often deal with financial planning including planning for retirement. Women's financial planning receives a very little attention (Hayes and Parker, 1993; Glass and Kilpatrick, 1998; Richardson, 1999; Hershey *et al.*, 2007; Perkins, 1995; Rosenman and Scott, 2009). At the global level, as the societal structure is changing, more and more women are stepping out of their traditional role as homemakers to participate in the earning workforce.

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As is evident from a report of the International Labour Organization (2016), in 2015, the female employment-to-population ratio was 46 percent. This indicates that women have had opportunities for procuring formal and paid employment. As rights and responsibilities go hand in hand, hence with increasing financial capability, women should take up responsibilities of managing their finances. Moreover, old age has specific implications for one's financial state, and women are more likely to suffer from poverty in early age as compared to men (UN Women, 2015). Women often outlive men, devote less time in the workforce due to their caregiving roles, usually participate in part-time jobs/less paid jobs/service positions which are not covered under pension plans, avail less pension benefits and lower wages due to gender differences and have less access to land and other assets which could support them financially in their old age (UN Women, 2015).

### *1.1 Rationale of the study*

Women's financial planning for retirement received a little attention from the research world. The existing literature (Slevin and Wingrove, 1995; Keele and Alpert, 2013) is fragmented, mostly subjective in nature and limited in scope. There is a lack of comprehensive organization and systematic summarization of the knowledge and findings from previous studies. Hence, to address this gap, this study attempts to compile such studies under one umbrella and examine the status of research on women's retirement financial planning. Also, this paper intends to provide academicians and other researchers with a bird's eye view of the work carried out so far on this subject. In particular, this paper addressed the following issues:

(1) publication trends across time and geography regarding various indicators, namely, year, region and journals;

(2) research designs, methodologies and analytical techniques that have been used to study women's retirement financial planning behavior;

(3) to identify the determinants of women's retirement financial planning behavior; and

(4) to explore the gaps in the existing body of literature and suggest some potential directions for future research.

To find an answer to the above issues, this study systematically analyzed the extant literature on the subject. It performed various basic and advanced cross tabulations to identify the patterns and trends in the research. The structure of rest of the paper is as follows: Section 2 deals with the methodology. Section 3 describes the publication trends in the literature based on year and country of publications, publication activities and citation analysis. Section 4 discusses the trends in research designs. Section 5 is about the factors influencing the women's retirement financial planning behavior as identified from the literature. Lastly, Sections 6 discuss the gaps in the existing literature and the avenues for future research.

## 2. Research methodology

A systematic literature review is required to aggregate a large amount of data into a compact, transparent and reproducible format (Denyer and Tranfield, 2006). For searching the literature, various databases including Emerald Insight, EBSCO, Pro Quest and Google Scholar are used. The keywords set for the search were "Financial planning" OR "Retirement planning" OR "Retirement financial planning" in the abstract, title or keywords. The search includes all the relevant articles until November–December, 2017. Table I provides the summarization of the database search protocol for the study.

The database search resulted in 12,776 results. To ensure the extraction of relevant articles, we applied various delimiting conditions. These conditions are as follows:

- articles that either focused exclusively on women or on studies carried out on mixed samples (which include both men and women or households);
- articles on factors affecting retirement financial planning behavior in women;
- articles published in scholarly journals; and
- articles written in the English language.

After extracting 12,162 results from the second phase of a database search, we conducted the third phase of the search, wherein 864 abstracts were shortlisted. These abstracts pertained to women's retirement and financial planning. We then further scanned these abstracts for relevance toward the subject and duplicity. In total, 151 abstracts were then shortlisted and full texts were obtained. Few of the abstracts were not available in full-text form and hence we searched separately and then included them in the final sample. Figure 1 illustrates the search process.

**Table I.**
Database search protocol

| S. No. | Database | Search criteria Keywords or abstract or title | Period of search | Total no. of papers | Cumulative total |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Pro quest | "Financial planning" OR | December, 2017 | 828 | 828 |
| 2 | Emerald | "Retirement planning" OR | November, 2017 | 163 | 991 |
| 3 | EBSCO | "Retirement financial | December, 2017 | 4,969 | 5,960 |
| 4 | Google Scholar | planning" | November, 2017 | 6,816 | 12,776 |

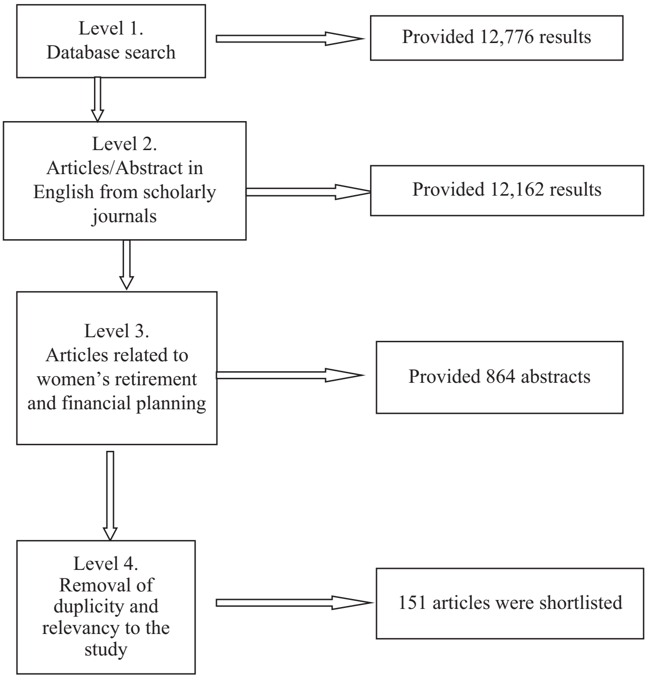


**Figure 1.**
Summary of the search process

## 3. Publication trends

The systematic review identified 151 scholarly journal articles. We further reviewed these articles and classified them under various categories. While doing so, we ensured that there is proper synchronization so that relevant, well-organized information is extracted.

### *3.1 Year and country of publication*

In this segment, the articles are distributed based on type of economy, year and country of publication. Table II indicates the distribution of studies over a span of 38 years, from 1980 to 2017.

Table II shows that there has been a rising trend from seven articles published until 1990 to 29 articles during 1991–2000 and finally 115 articles published during 2001–2017. In the past few years, studies have gained momentum, particularly so after 2006. This relatively steep rise in the number of publications after 2006 clearly shows the importance and the growing scope of research on women's retirement financial planning. There might be two reasons for the steep rise in the number of studies in the twenty-first century. First, in America, the twenty-first century has been the retirement century, as the baby boomer generation (those born between 1946 and 1964) was approaching retirement during this period and they encompassed one out of every third American (Glass and Kilpatrick, 1998). Second, there had been a gradual shift of pension plans from being "defined benefit" to "defined contribution." This meant that now individuals are supposed to take the responsibility for their retirement financial status. Both these major shifts might have led to the realization of the lack of retirement financial planning by women, which thereby attracted the attention of researchers.

Figure 2 depicts the distribution of the articles based on the economy of the countries. It indicates that the subject has been discussed in research articles predominantly only in developed economies, until 2000. Since 2001, women's financial planning gained some prominence in other parts of the globe, and particularly since 2010, there has been a surge in the number of studies in other countries as well.

### *3.2 Publication activity*

In total, 151 articles included in the review list are spread over 95 separate journals and are focused on subjects namely, finance, gerontology, economics, psychology and business. Table III provides the list of top 15 journals based on publication activity. These journals comprise 45.6 percent of the total publication activity. It can be further inferred from the table that out of these 15 journals, 6 journals are related to finance or economics and rests of the journals are related to fields like gerontology, psychology, aging, etc. This highlights the fact that the subject of women's retirement financial planning has acclaimed wide recognition in other disciplines as well. This leads to the fact that this subject is of importance not only from the financial or economic point of view but in disciplines like gerontology and psychology as well. This table will also be helpful for those academicians and future researchers who intend to explore and study the existing research work on women's retirement financial planning.

### *3.3 Citation analysis*

Citation analysis helps researchers to collect relevant literature and identify the important work carried out so far in a specific area. Through citation count, researchers can identify the number of times a specific paper had been referred to. Thus, one can directly relate the citation count to the quality of a particular study. We have collected the citation data for this study from Google Scholar citation index. We developed four citations metric to determine

**Table II.**
Distribution of articles by year and country of publication

| | | | 1991–2000 | | | | | 2001–2017 | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | Total |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Country | 1980–1990 | 1991–1995 | 1996 | 1997 | 1998 | 1999 | 2000 | 2001 | 2002 | 2003 | 2004 | 2005 | 2006 | 2007 | 2008 | 2009 | 2010 | 2011 | 2012 | 2013 | 2014 | 2015 | 2016 | 2017 | |
| Australia | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | 1 | X | 1 | X | 2 | X | 2 | 1 | X | 1 | X | X | 1 | X | 1 | **12** |
| Cross- National | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | **4** |
| Canada | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | 1 | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | **2** |
| Chile | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | X | X | X | **1** |
| China | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | **3** |
| Germany | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | 1 | X | X | X | X | X | X | **2** |
| India | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | 4 | 1 | X | **6** |
| Israel | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | **1** |
| Malaysia | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 2 | 2 | 1 | X | 1 | X | X | **6** |
| Netherlands | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | 1 | **2** |
| New Zealand | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 2 | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | X | **3** |
| Pakistan | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | 1 | X | X | **2** |
| Russia | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | X | X | X | **1** |
| South Africa | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | **1** |
| Sweden | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | X | X | X | **1** |
| UK | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | X | 1 | X | X | 1 | X | X | X | X | X | **3** |
| USA | 7 | 12 | 3 | 2 | 5 | 2 | 2 | 3 | 5 | 5 | 4 | 5 | 2 | 8 | 4 | 6 | 7 | 4 | 2 | 3 | 3 | 1 | 4 | 2 | **101** |
| Total | **7** | **12** | **4** | **2** | **5** | **2** | **4** | **3** | **6** | **7** | **5** | **7** | **2** | **12** | **4** | **9** | **12** | **10** | **6** | **7** | **5** | **9** | **5** | **6** | **151** |

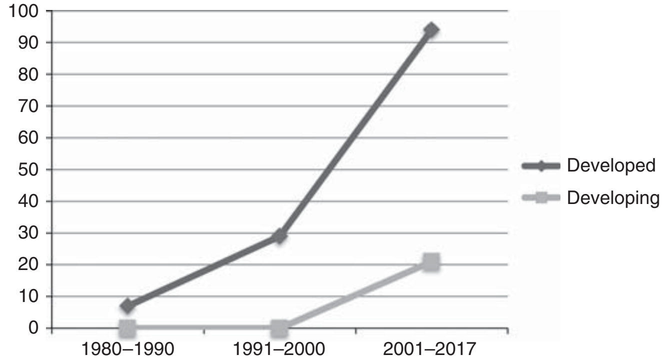


**Figure 2.** Distribution of articles based on the type of economy

| S. No. | Journal title | Publisher | Number of publications |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1. | *Journal of Women and Aging* | Taylor and Francis Online | 12 |
| 2. | *Journal of Financial Counseling and Planning* | Association for Financial Counseling and Planning Education | 12 |
| 3. | *Educational Gerontology* | Taylor and Francis Online | 7 |
| 4. | *The Gerontologist* | Oxford Academic | 6 |
| 5. | *Journal of Pension Economics and Finance* | Cambridge University Press | 5 |
| 6. | *Journal of Family and Economic Issues* | Springer International Publishing | 4 |
| 7. | *International Journal of Aging and Human Development* | SAGE Publishing | 4 |
| 8. | *Financial Service Review* | Academy of Financial Services-Elsevier | 4 |
| 9. | *Journal of Women, Politics, and Policy* | Taylor and Francis | 3 |
| 10. | *AFFILIA: Journal of Women and Social Work* | SAGE Publications | 2 |
| 11. | *Financial Analyst Journal* | Chartered Financial Analyst Institute | 2 |
| 12. | *Journal of Applied Gerontology* | SAGE Publications | 2 |
| 13. | *Journal of Personal Finance* | International Association of Registered Financial Consultants (IARFC) | 2 |
| 14. | *Research on Aging* | SAGE Publications | 2 |
| 15. | *Journal of Aging Studies* | Elsevier | 2 |

**Table III.** Distribution of articles based on publication in journals

the most significant papers and the most prolific authors. The criteria for development of metrics are as follows:

(1) Total Citations: it is based on the number of citations from the year of publication to November–December, 2017.

(2) Number of citations per year: the basis for this is the number of citations since the year of publication divided by the number of years from publication to November–December, 2017.

(3) Number of citations per author: it is calculated by dividing the number of citations from the year of publication to November–December, 2017, by the number of authors.

(4) Number of citations per author per year: it is based on the number of citations from the year of publication to November–December, 2017, divided by the number of authors, which in turn is divided by the number of years from publication to November–December, 2017.

Table IV provides the citation metrics wherein we included the top 20 articles based on the total citation count. Next, by citations per year, citations per author and citations per author per year, we identified the top 20 articles and added them to the list. In all, the final list had 25 articles. The most cited publications are (Croson and Gneezy, 2009) (3198 total citations and 355.33 citations per year) followed by Lusardi and Mitchell (2007a) (1443 total citations and 131.18 citations per year). Other influential studies in the field include among others: Sunden and Surette (1998), Bajtelsmit and Bernasek (1996) and Lusardi and Mitchell (2011a, 2007b).

Citations per author and citations per author per year are other important indexes, which can be useful to identify the most prolific authors in the field. As can be identified from the table, Croson and Gneezy (2009) is at the top of the list with 177.66 citations per author per year. Lusardi and Mitchell (2007a, b, 2011a) are other significant authors who have contributed to the area. Lusardi and Mitchell have worked extensively on financial literacy and its association with retirement financial planning. We can further infer from the table that out of the list of 25 articles, 22 articles had their publication in 2000 or later. This, thus, provided evidence of the growing research trend in this area in the twenty-first century.

Another significant finding from the table is that out of these 25 articles only two articles focused exclusively on baby boomers or women's retirement financial planning. To understand women's retirement financial planning, it is necessary to study the subject in light of the various opportunities and odds faced by a woman. More such retirement financial planning studies need promotion, which focus only on women, rather than placing them as an ancillary to men.

## 4. Trends in research designs

In this section, we classified the articles based on the data collection and the type of study:

(1) empirical studies include articles based on some observations, experiments and analysis; and

(2) conceptual studies include articles related to the development of some concept, theoretical and literature review papers.

Of the 151 articles, 117 are empirical, and 34 are conceptual. This signifies the preference of doing empirical research. Of the 117 empirical studies, 100 studies used quantitative research methods, 15 used qualitative methods and 2 were based on a mixed method approach (using both qualitative and quantitative methods). Figure 3 shows the distribution of articles by research method.

The search shows that majority of the empirical studies are survey based, with 65 studies on primary data and 32, are based on secondary data collected from other national surveys. In the qualitative research approach, semi-structured interviews were the most popular option, followed by focus group studies. As inferred from the earlier section, research on women's retirement financial planning is in a very nascent stage and that the majority of the studies have taken place in the recent years. Despite this, the emphasis is on quantitative empirical research methods over qualitative methods. This might lead to biased research, which might provide debatable, inconsistent and ambiguous research findings. To explore new insights into the subject and to develop a more robust, wider and multivariate framework, more qualitative studies are required.

On further analysis, it was identified that of the 151 articles included in the review, only 54 articles are women-centric, and focused exclusively on women as the sample, 97 studies are based on mixed samples including both men and women or households. This signifies the dearth of studies that concentrate only on women's retirement financial planning and its various aspects. To understand women's retirement financial planning, it is a need to explore the issue in light of the various contingencies faced by women, whether it is at

| S. No. | Title of the paper | Year | Author | Total citation count (rank) | Citations per year (rank) | Citations per author (rank) | Citations per author per year (rank) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. | Gender Differences in Preferences | (2009) | Croson and Gneezy | 3,198 (1) | 355.33 (1) | 1,599 (1) | 177.66 (1) |
| 2. | Baby Boomer Retirement Security: The Roles of Planning, Financial Literacy and Housing Wealth | (2007a) | Lusardi and Mitchell | 1,443 (2) | 131.18 (3) | 721.5 (2) | 65.59 (3) |
| 3. | Financial Literacy and Planning: Implication for Retirement Well-being | (2011a) | Lusardi and Mitchell | 1,214 (3) | 173.42 (2) | 607 (3) | 86.71 (2) |
| 4. | Financial Literacy and Retirement Preparedness: Evidence and Implications for Financial Education | (2007b) | Lusardi and Mitchell | 1,061 (4) | 96.45 (4) | 530.5 (4) | 48.22 (4) |
| 5. | Gender Differences in the Allocation of Assets in Retirement Saving Plans | (1998) | Sunden and Surette | 814 (5) | 40.7 (9) | 407 (5) | 20.35 (11) |
| 6. | Planning and Financial Literacy: How Do Women Fare? | (2008) | Lusardi and Mitchell | 730 (6) | 73 (6) | 365 (7) | 36.5 (6) |
| 7. | Financial Literacy Around the World: An Overview | (2011b) | Lusardi and Mitchell | 617 (7) | 88.14 (5) | 308.5 (8) | 44.07 (5) |
| 8. | How Ordinary Consumers Make Complex Economic Decisions: Financial Literacy and Retirement Readiness | (2009) | Lusardi and Mitchell | 455 (8) | 56.875 (8) | 227.5 (9) | 25.277 (9) |
| 9. | Strong Evidence for Gender Differences in Risk Taking | (2012) | Charness and Gneezy | 435 (9) | 72.5 (7) | 217.5 (10) | 36.25 (7) |
| 10. | Why Do Women Invest Differently than Men | (1996) | Bajtelsmit and Bernasek | 415 (10) | 18.86 (18) | 207.5 (11) | 9.43 (20) |
| 11. | Financial Risk Tolerance and Additional Factors that Affect Risk Taking in Everyday Money Matters | (2000) | Grable | 373 (11) | 20.72 (15) | 373 (6) | 20.722 (10) |
| 12. | Gender Differences in Revealed Risk Taking: Evidence from Mutual Fund Investors | (2002) | Dwyer *et al.* | 369 (12) | 23.06 (14) | 123 (16) | 7.68 (23) |
| 13. | Gender, Risk, and Retirement | (2001) | Bernasek and Shwiff | 326 (13) | 19.17 (17) | 163 (14) | 9.588 (19) |
| 14. | Do Female Mutual Fund Managers Manage Differently? | (2003) | Atkinson *et al.* | 271 (14) | 18.06 (19) | 90.33 (27) | 6.022 (26) |
| 15. | Does Risk Tolerance Decrease with Age? | (1997) | Wang and Hanna | 255 (15) | 12.14 (24) | 127.5 (15) | 6.07 (25) |
| 16. | Financial Literacy and Retirement Planning in Germany | (2011) | Bucher-Koenen and Lusardi | 245 (16) | 35 (10) | 122.5 (17) | 17.5 (12) |
| 17. | An Exploratory Framework of the Determinants of Financial Satisfaction | (2004) | Joo and Grable | 241 (17) | 17.21 (20) | 120.5 (18) | 8.60 (21) |

(*continued*)

**Table IV.** List of studies according to their citation counts

| S. No. | Title of the paper | Year | Author | Total citation count (rank) | Citations per year (rank) | Citations per author (rank) | Citations per author per year (rank) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 18. | Gender Differences in Risk Aversion and Expected Retirement Benefits | (2007) | Watson and Mcnaughton | 219 (18) | 19.90 (16) | 109.5 (20) | 9.95 (18) |
| 19. | Psychological Determinant of Financial Preparedness for Retirement | (2000) | Hershey and Mowen | 206 (19) | 11.44 (25) | 103 (21) | 5.72 (27) |
| 20. | Psychological Perspective on the Changing Nature of Retirement | (2011) | Shultz and Wang | 201 (20) | 28.71 (11) | 100.5 (22) | 14.35 (13) |
| 21. | Planning and Saving for Retirement | (2003) | Lusardi | 191 (23) | 12.8 (23) | 192 (12) | 12.8 (14) |
| 22. | Americans' Financial Capability | (2011) | Lusardi | 185 (24) | 26.42 (12) | 185 (13) | 26.42 (8) |
| 23. | How Financial Literacy and Impatience Shape Retirement Wealth and Investment Behaviors | (2011) | Hastings and Mitchell | 174 (25) | 24.85 (13) | 87 (28) | 12.42 (15) |
| 24. | A Literature Review on the Effectiveness of Financial Education | (2007) | Martin | 116 (28) | 10.54 (26) | 116 (19) | 10.54 (16) |
| 25. | Gender Difference in Personal Saving Behaviors | (2010) | Fisher | 84 (43) | 10.5 (27) | 84 (29) | 10.5 (17) |

**Table IV.**

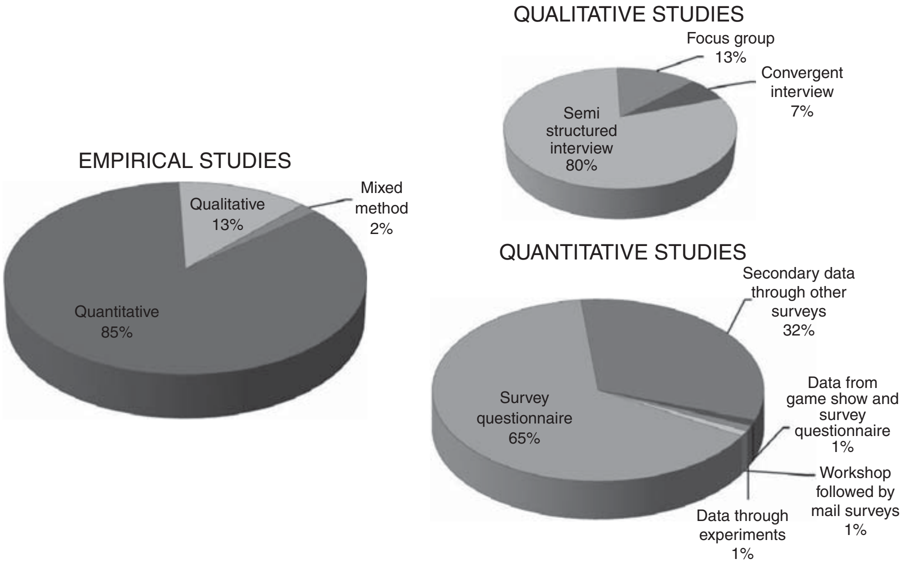


**Figure 3.**
Distribution of articles by research method

home or work. Hence, more such studies are required, which place women as their central theme, rather than those that place women as an adjunct to men or as a part of a study on gender differences.

*4.1 Statistical techniques and methods*

In this section, we classified the articles based on statistical techniques/tools to determine the most popular technique used for analysis. Figures 4 and 5 give an overview of the various quantitative and qualitative techniques used, along with their respective frequencies. As can be observed, amongst the quantitative analytical tools, regression analysis is the most popular and frequently used technique. Apart from regression, some researchers have also applied techniques such as structural equation modeling (SEM). It studies the causal relationships between the measured variable and the posited latent constructs. As the studies on the psychological and social forces affecting retirement financial planning are increasing, so is the application of SEM. SEM is a confirmatory measurement and due to its comprehensive approach in assessing the models, it is frequently used in other psychological and social sciences studies also Anderson and Gerbing (1988). Other than regression and SEM, *t*-statistics, correlation and descriptive analysis are also applied.

Figure 5 shows the distribution of techniques when using the qualitative approach. This indicates that the majority of the studies used thematic content analysis, followed by Grounded Theory and case study approach.

## 5. Determinants of women's retirement financial planning behavior: content analysis

Personal financial planning over the past few decades has emerged as a discipline, which is of utmost importance to an individual. It is an ever-evolving process that incorporates all the

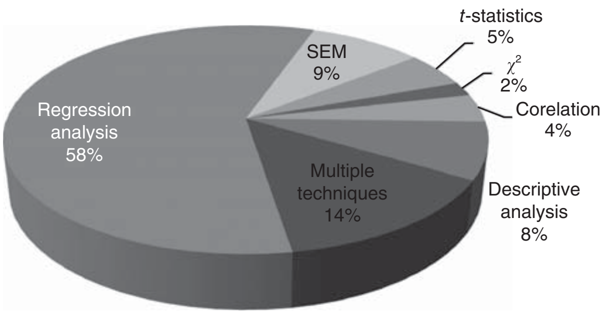


**Figure 4.** Distribution of studies based on quantitative statistical techniques

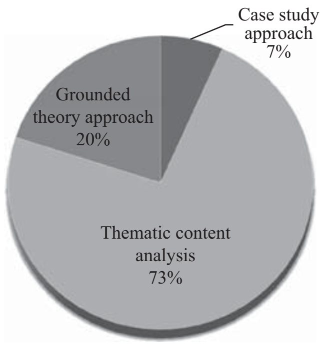


**Figure 5.** Distribution of articles based on the qualitative approach to analysis

financial items like savings, investments, taxation, estate planning, cash flow management insurance planning and retirement planning.

Retirement planning is a life cycle planning for the duration when the person is out of the workforce, and work-related income ceases to exist. By examining the 151 articles, the paper analyzes the research on retirement financial planning, particularly concerning women. It further tries to understand the various inhibiting and accelerating factors of women's retirement financial planning behavior. On comprehensive examination of the literature, we identified that planning and saving practices differ by socio-demographic characteristics, the psychological dimensions, economic factors and social forces. In the following paragraphs, the focus is on the review of various studies concerning each of these variables.

### *5.1 Socio-demographic factors*

"Age" is one of the most striking characteristics of an individual. Studies carried out by Clark *et al.* (2009), Hershey *et al.* ( 2010), Turner *et al.* (1994) and Adams and Rau (2011) suggest that age has a direct and positive influence on retirement financial planning. Older pre-retirees are more actively involved in financial planning as compared to their younger counterparts. A possible explanation for this relationship is that at a younger age, retirement seems a distant event and presents a long-term timeline to think and plan for. However, at an older age, when people approach retirement, they often indulge actively in planning for it. Apart from this direct impact, age also interacts with other psychological variables such as attitude toward retirement, risk tolerance to render an indirect influence. Strei and Schneiders (1971) (as cited in Prentis, 1980) discussed the relationship between age and attitude toward retirement. It stated that the younger the individual, the more favorable is the attitude toward retirement. The development of a negative perception with progression in age is attributable to the fact that as retirement approaches, one develops fear and apprehension regarding growing age, dependency, health issues, lack of planning (Bard *et al.,* 1977 (as cited in Prentis, 1980)). Prentis (1980) also discovered through a study that women look forward to retirement when they were mostly in the age group of 40–49 years as compared to any other age range. In contrast to attitude, the financial risk tolerance increases with age. Wang and Hanna (1997) and Grable (2000) conducted studies wherein, they found that risk tolerance increases with age and that older individuals invest into riskier assets.

Another socio-demographic determinant of financial planning is retirement age. An increase in retirement age ensures an increase in the duration of a person's earning life to build up financial security and at the same time also decrease the postretirement years to be supported by such backups. Moreover, longer employment tenure also increases the type and the number of retirement benefits. As is evident from a study by Kock and Yoong (2011), the expected retirement age affects one's orientation and financial preparations.

Gender is another significant demographic characteristic that influences retirement financial planning. There are two schools of thoughts regarding women's investment patterns: one considers that women are more risk averse in selection of their entire portfolio of assets and the other group emphasizes that if controlled for factors like income and education then this gender difference is insignificant. The financial concept for risk and return emphasizes that it is always a tradeoff between risk and return. If women are less willing to take risks, then they should expect to accumulate less wealth as well. Several studies have found that women have relatively conservative investment strategies, and thus they allocate a smaller percentage of their wealth to stocks as compared to bonds (Bajtelsmit and Bernasek, 1996; Bajtelsmit *et al.*, 1999).

Other studies conducted by Croson and Gneezy (2009), Glass and Kilpatrick (1998), Clark *et al.* (2009) and Charness and Gneezy (2012) also confirmed that women are more risk aversive as far as financial investments are considered. Sunden and Surette (1998) and Bernasek and Shwiff (2001) investigated cohabitating or married couples to study the effect of risk averseness on household financial decisions. They identified that their findings are similar to those in single women. Women irrespective of their spouse's risk tolerance choose less risky investment decisions. Fisher (2010) found that risk tolerance not only affects portfolios but also saving tendencies in both men and women. Women who are more risk averse are less prone to save over the short term and in addition are irregular savers. Another school of thought advocates that if controlled for factors such as income and education then this gender preference in selection of risky portfolio is insignificant. Coleman (2003) discovered that when one held education and wealth constant, women owned the same level of stocks and mutual funds as a percentage of net worth as compared to what men owned. A possible explanation for such behavior could be that a higher education enables one to have a higher source of income, which in turn provides a cushion or a financial backup to offset any possible loss.

In another study by Atkinson *et al.* (2003) that focused on mutual fund managers, the findings were consistent that there is no difference between funds managed by males and females, regardless of whether it is about risk and performance or other fund characteristics. This further supports the fact that the difference in behavior is attributable to factors including investment knowledge and wealth consistency. Another aspect of the gender influence on retirement financial management is the difference in spending pattern. Lee (2003) discovered that females tend to devote their time in retirement planning activities such as living arrangements, daily activities, post-retirement lifestyle and health issues. These issues are far away from the financial aspects of retirement planning. Men, however, focus on saving money for their retirement and display better retirement financial planning (Joo and Pauwels, 2002; Fernández-López *et al.*, 2015).

Doda (2014) concluded that females are more sensitive and spend more money on materialistic objects such as remodeling of their house; gifts to relatives, coworkers, friends, donations and vacation. This tends to increase their cost of living and depletes their savings for retirement. Noone *et al.* (2010) discovered that in terms of informal planning and retirement perception, men and women are on the same level and showed no difference. Morgan and Eckert (2004) and Bucher-Koenen and Lusardi (2011) also found that gender did not have any significant effect on financial planning. Rosplock (2010) analyzed the perception of men and women on wealth and discovered that men are more knowledgeable in terms of tax and insurance planning and even considered them as being more affluent in financial decision making. In contrast, women are less confident and expressed desire for gaining additional knowledge and are keenly interested in keeping a check on how socially responsible investments they were making.

Income is another variable that significantly influences financial planning. Moorthy *et al.* (2012) indicated that "Earning or Income" level directly influences expenditures and savings of an individual. Hence, it is positively associated with retirement financial planning behavior. According to a study by Bucher-Koenen and Lusardi (2011), retirement planning is directly and positively proportionate to income. Kock and Yoong (2011), Kilty and Behling (1986), Turner *et al.* (1994) and Jacobs-Lawson *et al.* (2004) also suggested that higher income is associated with higher involvement in financial planning. In another study conducted by Bernasek and Bajtelsmit (2002), where particularly they analyzed women's involvement in household financial decision making, they found that their share of household income and financial education directly and positively influenced women's say in financial decisions.

An occupational position of an individual affects many aspects of life, like the financial income, financial exposure, status, lifestyle, etc. A study was conducted by Foster (2012) regarding women's financial planning and it was discovered that women who were in intermediate/professional or managerial roles were more proactive in their financial planning. They started planning early for retirement. Moreover, they were more risk tolerant in their financial investments, as identified by Croson and Gneezy (2009) and

Atkinson *et al.* (2003). However, those in routine and manual jobs thought 40 years to be an appropriate age to start thinking about retirement. They were also less likely to have access to any occupational pension schemes (Foster, 2012).

Another socio-demographic determinant is family structure. Traditionally, we consider women as the predominant gender responsible for the upbringing of children, looking after the husband and providing care for all family members, relatives, parents, etc. This caregiving role proves to be tremendously costly regarding time, energy and money. This typical pattern has resulted in interrupted work histories for women. They randomly enter and exit from the labor market to fulfill their family responsibilities. All these factors have contributed toward women being in low paid jobs, part-time jobs or in service sector positions. As discovered by Turner *et al.* (1994), a greater number of dependent children in a family leave less room for financial planning. The findings of Wang and Hanna (1997), Szinovacz *et al.* (2001), Chatterjee and Zahirovic-Herbert (2010) and Glass and Kilpatrick (1998) were consistent, where the number of children is negatively correlated with retirement planning. The reason for such an association is that the presence of children increases the current consumption while reducing the resources available for future household savings and investments.

Marriage can also have a significant influence on women's retirement financial planning both directly and indirectly. Women with a working spouse can pool their incomes and can have better accessibility to enhanced financial resources. This enables them to prepare better for the future. Many unmarried women have expressed their inabilities regarding both, the lack of resources and psychological support systems, as discovered by Noone *et al.* (2010), Behling *et al.* (1983) and Damman *et al.* (2014). Grable (2000) and Schooley and Worden (1996) studied factors that affect risk tolerance and found that married individuals are more risk tolerant than those who were unmarried. Further, Richardson (1999) conducted a study that depicts that a spouse's retirement age also has its share of effect on women's retirement. Husbands who retire early in their lives often persuade their female counterparts to opt for early retirement, which ultimately affects their future financial planning.

### *5.2 Psychological factors*

Relative to the work done in socio-demography, research in psychological factors underlying retirement financial planning behavior is in a very nascent stage. Very few studies have attempted to capture the influence of psychological factors on retirement financial planning (Hershey *et al.,* 2007; Hershey *et al.,* 2010). Based on the existing body of literature, these dimensions are attitude toward retirement, future time perspective, locus of control, financial risk tolerance and retirement goal clarity.

Attitude is one's perception toward any person, object, situation or an idea. In a broader aspect, it is an outlook toward life, and like many other spheres, it influences retirement planning behavior as well. According to Ajzen (1991), one with a positive outlook toward a certain action has a greater tendency to follow that behavior. In line with the above concept, studies have been conducted, and it has been identified that perception toward retirement is directly and positively associated with retirement financial planning (Moorthy *et al.*, 2012; Turner *et al.,* 1994; Noone *et al.*, 2010; Gordon, 1994). Further, factors, namely, age, income (Wiggins and Henderson, 1996; Turner *et al.*, 1994) and work involvement (Noone *et al.*, 2010; Kasworm and Wetzel, 1981) also influence attitude. Income has a direct positive influence, whereas age and work involvement have a negative relationship with attitude.

As a woman grows older, she tends to develop a negative attitude and apprehension about retirement. Similarly, more involvement in work and orientation of social contacts toward occupational colleagues also results in a negative attitude. The reason for this is that a woman faces a loss of identity and drifts aloof once she has retired or stepped out of the workforce.

The degree of association or interaction varies, where income and age have a strong association but workforce involvement showed a weak indirect effect on attitude.

The next psychological factor is future time perspective. This defines the extent or boundary of how far into the future one can visualize. Hershey *et al.* (2010) characterized this as the "Central" personality trait and found that it influences the future financial planning. It imparts its effect by affecting one's knowledge and involvement in financial planning procedures, as indicated through studies carried out by Hershey and Mowen (2000) and Hershey *et al.* (2007). The emphasis on the importance of planning further positively influences the levels of savings (Glass and Kilpatrick, 1998). Jacobs-Lawson and Hershey (2005) stated that when defining the future time perspective concerning the economic literature, one often refers to characteristics such as patience, planning horizons and time preferences. Hastings and Mitchell (2011) conducted a study to determine the effect of impatience on retirement wealth and investment behavior. They discovered that impatient investors or those who choose current gratifications tend to make shortsighted investment choices. Similarly, Griffin *et al.* (2012) also discovered that those individuals who were high in time discounting were less involved in retirement planning. A possible explanation is that such people focused more on current reward rather than on saving for the future.

Another psychological factor is locus of control. It represents a characteristic of human personality, whereby one associates the success or failure of either oneself or the external environment. Depending on the nature of association, it can be the external locus of control or internal locus of control. People with the external locus of control believe the external factors such as fate, luck and destiny govern their life, whereas people with an internal locus of control perceive the positive and negative events of their lives as consequences of their actions. They, thus, tend to step ahead and take charge of their lives. External loci of control personalities are dependent on others including their spouse, children, parents, friends and relatives to make decisions on their behalf. Women often tend to display an external locus of control and as is evident in a study by Glass and Kilpatrick (1998). McKenna and Nichols (1988), Morgan and Eckert (2004), Sumarwan and Hira (1993) and Anderson *et al.* (2000) discovered that the external locus of control is negatively related to financial preparation and financial status. Perkins (1995) and Hayes and Parker (1993) opined that women often have a myth in their minds that through marriage they can find their life partner who will not only look after their present finances but also simultaneously plan for their future retirement.

Another psychological determinant of retirement financial planning is retirement goal clarity. Stawski *et al.* (2007) and Hershey *et al.* (2007) determined the effect of goal clarity on retirement saving contributions and discovered that goal clarity is a significant predictor of planning activities and planning, in turn, affects savings contributions. Thus, via the planning construct, goal clarity influences savings. Similarly, Moorthy *et al.* (2012) discovered that goal clarity affects retirement planning such that individuals with clear goals tend to indulge in active retirement planning. Hershey *et al.* (2010) also mentioned that the establishment of clearer and realistic goals enhance the financial planning activity and savings contributions. Goal clarity, in turn, is influenced by factors including age, early learning, support from spouse, support from friends and colleagues (Hershey *et al.*, 2010; Stawski *et al.*, 2007).

### *5.3 Financial literacy*

A key issue that engulfs modern households is why the majorities fail to save for retirement are too much in debt, have poor mortgage decisions and struggle with other day-to-day financial problems. A possible explanation, as proposed by Hastings and Mitchell (2011), is financial illiteracy. According to their study, financial literacy is associated with retirement savings. Lusardi and Mitchell (2008) carried out a study specifically on women, discovered that financial literacy is strongly and positively associated with retirement planning. Those giving correct answers to financial literacy questions turned out to be successful planners. Further, this also points to the lower level of financial literacy in women.

In line with the above study, Bucher-Koenen and Lusardi (2011) researched in Germany and concluded that financial planning and financial literacy were positively associated such that households that had planned for retirement tended to be more financially literate as compared to others. Moreover, financial literacy also interacts with other demographic variables, such as gender (females were less financially literate as compared to males), education level and income (Rosplock, 2010; Estes and Hosseini, 1988; Graham *et al.*, 2002; Thompson *et al.,* 1998; Bucher-Koenen and Lusardi, 2011; Hastings and Mitchell, 2011; Lusardi and Mitchell, 2009). A tentative explanation for the association between income and financial literacy is that the higher the income, the more money will be available at one's disposal and this will probably accelerate one's effort to look around for investment opportunities and acquire more information.

Lusardi and Mitchell (2007a) reported that better retirement planning is associated with more wealth accumulation for the post-retirement period. Planning activity is in lieu affected by financial literacy, and the association between planning and wealth accumulation holds strong, even after controlling for socio-demographic factors. Lusardi and Mitchell (2009) and Hershey *et al.* (2010) also conducted studies at this theme and concluded that financial knowledge is closely correlated with retirement planning and that this relationship further imparted a positive influence on savings for retirement.

### *5.4 Social factors*

Human beings are influenced by the social groups around them. The specific effect of social forces on women's retirement planning has not received much attention in the literature. Despite this, there are studies like the one conducted by Griffin *et al.* (2012) where it was identified that females are more strongly affected by cultural and social norms. They are more likely to undertake any planning behavior when their close ones are involved in any such act. Lusardi (2003) also advocates the fact that any form of financial planning is partly shaped by the experience and learning of other individuals, be it, siblings or parents. Also, such planning affects wealth holdings and portfolio choices, for particularly high return assets like stocks. Hershey *et al.* (2010) investigated the influence of support of friends and coworkers, spouse and parents on financial planning of an individual and suggested that social networks can influence directly or indirectly. Indirectly they can impart their effect through affecting time of women's departure from the workforce (Richardson, 1999) or through the level of satisfaction and adjustment postretirement. Directly they render an effect on the future time perspective and retirement goal clarity (Hershey *et al.*, 2010).

### *5.5 Circumstantial factors*

Circumstances often shape up the behavior of an individual. Kemp *et al.* (2005) carried out a study to determine catalysts and constraints of financial planning. They discovered that employers' programs and retirement courses are catalysts for retirement financial planning. However, jobless and unforeseen expenses are constraints of financial planning. Further, there were a few events such as the death of spouse, divorce or remarriage, which served both the purposes. Lusardi (2003) also discovered that financial planning is associated with financial shocks and health issues. A financial shock could be either negative (e.g. unemployment) or positive (e.g. sudden inheritances, insurance settlements or any financial assistance from relatives or friends). Chatterjee and Zahirovic-Herbert (2010) found health to be positively associated with retirement planning.

*5.6 Economic factors*

Economic factor such as the cost of living in an area at a given period also plays a role in retirement planning. Financial planning is dependent on time and geography, and it is often associated with state policies and practices. Each country is bound to develop its unique pattern of planning (Kemp *et al.*, 2005). For example, each country has its fiscal policies that affect a nation's economy, right from interest rates to tax schemes. In America, the changes in the pension system and swift shift from defined benefit to Defined Contribution Scheme influenced the level of retirement wealth (Lusardi, 2011). Canadians have universal access to the basic health care system, and they pay less of college tuition fees as compared to what Americans do. Moreover, they have universal flat benefits for seniors (Kemp *et al.*, 2005). In the USA, the focus is on personal liability of financing oneself in retirement, whereas in the Netherlands, the approach is collective of pension financing. These structural differences in pension schemes lead to different saving pressures on individuals (Hershey *et al.*, 2010). Hence, the literature suggests that the geography and the period directly influence the retirement planning.

Based on the above findings from the literature a blueprint/conceptual framework of factors influencing women's retirement financial planning is generated. Figure 6 presents the model. The rationale behind the conceptual model is to logically integrate all the potential influential factors to deliver a framework that provides the most suitable explanation for occurrence of an event (Brown *et al.*, 1995).

## 6. Research gaps and future research avenues

Globally, although the women workforce participation rate has increased, the attitude of women toward finance and retirement is still encapsulated under traditional norms. Despite the fact that women are more susceptible to poverty in post-retirement years, they fail to realize the importance of timely retirement financial planning. They lack in proper financial management and are the most vulnerable and financially fragile group (UN Women, 2015; Keele and Alpert, 2013; de Bassa Scheresberg *et al.*, 2014; Malone *et al.*, 2010).

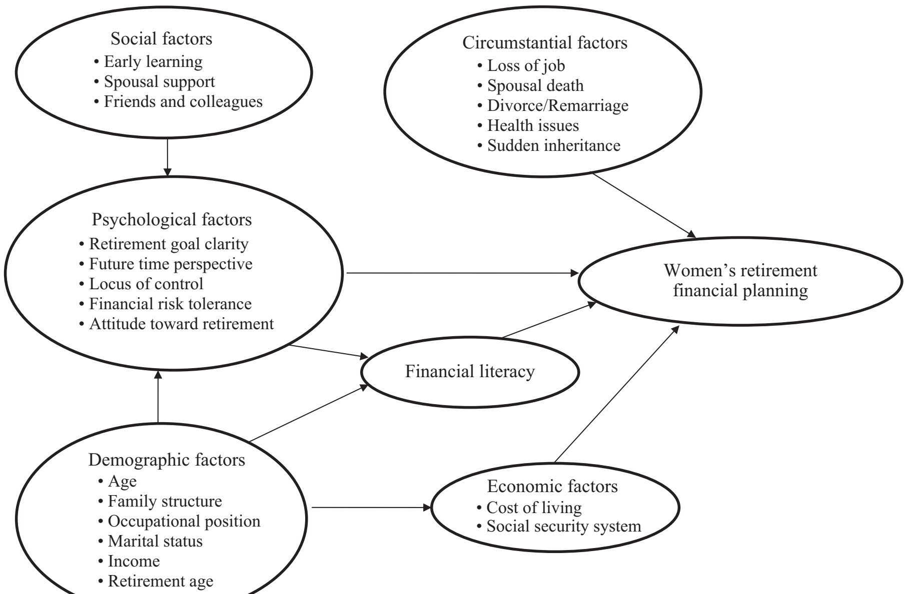


**Figure 6.** Conceptual framework for retirement financial planning of women

The overarching aim of this study is to investigate the extant literature on the conceptualization of women's retirement financial planning and present a systematic summarization of the knowledge. At the same time, we also attempt to study the various accelerating and inhibiting factors of women's active engagement in retirement financial planning behavior as presented in the literature.

It can be inferred from the review that only a few studies have focused their research exclusively toward women's retirement financial planning behavior (Szinovacz *et al.*, 2001; Wong and Hardy, 2009; Damman *et al.*, 2014; Noone *et al.*, 2010; Price 2002). Most of the literature available is on savings, investments and financial planning in general. In these studies, women are mostly placed as an adjunct to men or as a part of any study on gender preferences. Women face many exigencies both at home and at the workplace, which might affect her financial planning behavior. Hence, we should study her behavior in light of all the issues faced by her because she is a woman.

The research in the area seems to be in a very nascent stage, lacking even a solid theoretical framework or foundation. The majority of the studies have based themselves on a quantitative research approach. Since the subject has not gained much maturity and most of the research took place in the recent past only. So a more exploratory qualitative approach should be adopted, to develop new insight and a more holistic, sturdy and multifaceted model of women's retirement financial planning.

This literature review also indicates the dominance of retirement and financial planning studies in developed countries especially in the USA and Australia. In developing economies, there is a dearth of studies. This provides a wide scope to determine whether the factors identified concerning women's retirement financial planning in developed economies are prevalent and consistent in emerging economies as well. Moreover, factors such as cultural and social norms render a stronger influence on women (Griffin *et al.*, 2012). So, more studies should be conducted in this context to provide insightful knowledge.

As posited by the retirement planning model developed by Hershey (2004), a set of factors, namely, psychological factors, task characteristics, cultural influences, and financial resources influence the investor's behavior. Further, this suggests that the psychological forces, in turn, depend on the resources available and cultural ethos. The psychological factors underlying retirement financial planning behavior are not studied in details (Hershey *et al.*, 2007, 2010).

Moreover, there are certain psychological forces like risk aversive behavior, which is both influential and contradictory in the case of women. One school of thought considers women's investment pattern as more risk aversive (Glass and Kilpatrick, 1998; Clark *et al.*, 2009; Charness and Gneezy, 2012) and another school emphasizes that if controlled for income and education, this difference is insignificant (Coleman, 2003; Atkinson *et al.*, 2003). Therefore, we should carry out further research to clear such ambiguities.

The literature review has documented the association between financial literacy and retirement financial planning. Even if one possesses surplus resources, the right approach and a conducive atmosphere, it is necessary to have awareness of how, where and when to invest to reap the maximum benefits/returns. At the same time, females have been reported to have displayed low levels of financial literacy (Lusardi and Mitchell, 2008, 2009; Bucher-Koenen and Lusardi, 2011; Martin, 2007). It can be explored how low financial literacy in females affect their retirement financial planning directly or indirectly.

The systematic review is a critical step toward the accumulation of the available knowledge before we can further disseminate it for development of a more integrative, conceptually sound and practically relevant explanation of an event. While the study includes various peer-reviewed scholarly journal articles retrieved from various databases, it suffers from certain inherent limitations as well. Although we used different databases to provide a wide coverage of the studies on the subject, certain additional studies beyond the scope of the databases used might have been neglected. Therefore, this study should be considered as basic groundwork toward the understanding of women's retirement financial planning, its current state and the direction toward which the research is heading.

From the application perspective, the study provides a brief review of the research done so far regarding the subject. It highlights the various factors affecting women's retirement financial planning behavior along with their respective relationships. This will serve as an addition to existing pool of knowledge. At the same time, it also highlights the gap in existing body of literature, which can provide a better direction and open up avenues for further research in the area.

Although a lot has been explored regarding the women's financial planning from retirement point of view, much is left to be further probed. The issue warrants some immediate and in-depth examination to answer the question – Why women fail to save a reasonable retirement wealth for their post-retirement years?

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